

Unseeded and returning from injury, Gayatri Gopichand and Treesa Jolly became the **unexpected stars** of India's home World Championships. Their bronze could signal the beginning of something bigger.

crowd chanting the names of these two women's doubles players in a World Championships semifinal. Gayatri and Treesa were unseeded. They had come in after missing much of this year following injury problems for Treesa.

Sure, everyone knew they were talented, and they had already shown that they could trouble the best. But a place in the last four of the biggest tournament in badminton, and 8,000 people so invested in them that they had created their own chant? That's the stuff dreams are made of.

India had not won a World Championships medal in women's doubles since Jwala Gutta and Ashwini Ponnappa took bronze in 2011. For 15 years, the discipline had been searching for another pair capable of carrying Indian badminton to a podium at its biggest tournament.

Gayatri and Treesa did it.

What made their run even more enjoyable was that they did so in a

tournament in which they were not supposed to be one of the stories.

The World Championships had come to Delhi carrying all the usual expectations of a home event. There was the pressure on India's established stars, the anticipation around Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty, the questions surrounding Lakshya Sen, five-time Worlds medallist P.V. Sindhu and the broader hope that a home crowd might push an Indian player or pair towards a deep run. After the first round, most of the attention was on Ayush Shetty following his upset of top seed and defending champion Shi Yuqi of China.

All those other stars eventually faltered.

Gayatri and Treesa became part of the conversation one match at a time. They beat

Dream run: Treesa Jolly and Gayatri Gopichand turned an unlikely World Championships campaign into a breakthrough moment for Indian women's doubles. PTI

